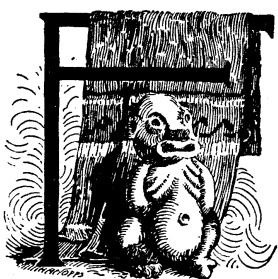




THE DESERTED HOMES OF A LOST PEOPLE.

THE SANTA BARBARA CHANNEL ISLANDS.



FEW of the thousands of people who pass within sight of the islands off the coast of Southern California know that the outlying and in most instances entirely uninhabited islands were formerly the homes of a people who have within a few decades become entirely extinct.

Some of these islands form the southerly line of the Santa Barbara Channel. From the combined causes of the sheltering islands seaward, the Santa Ynez

Mountains on the main land, the sudden trend of the coast line towards the east, and the presence of large quantities of petroleum rising from the bottom and covering large areas of the surface of the water, the ocean is nearly always calm and smooth.

When in 1542 Cabrillo, the famous Portuguese navigator, sailed from the west coast of New Spain, and discovered and visited the islands, he found them thickly populated, as was also the adjacent coast.

Ferrelo, one of Cabrillo's officers and the historian of the expedition, in speak-

ing of this region, says: "They anchored opposite a valley, very beautiful and very populous, the land being level, with many trees" (Carpinteria). "Here came canoes with fish to barter; they remained great friends; . . . they held on their voyage along the coast about ten leagues, and there were always many canoes, for all this coast is very populous, . . . and they pointed out to us the villages, and named them by their names."

Here follow the names of twenty-five villages, some of which are as follows: "Xucu," "Xabaagua," "Potoltuc," "Nacbuc," "Gua," "Incpupu," and other names equally euphonious. . . . "They go clothed with skins; they said that inland there were many towns."

The island "Limun" (Santa Cruz), the largest of the group, was said to be "very populous," and that it contained the following villages: "Niquipos," "Maxul," "Xugua," "Nitel," "Macamo," and "Nimitopal."

"Nicalque" (Santa Rosa), the next in importance, the navigators at first supposed was a portion of Limun, and called the two La Isla de San Lucas.

The island of "Ciquimuymu" (San Miguel), was also very thickly inhabited.

"Enneeapah" (Anacapa), the easternmost of the Channel Islands proper, was not visited by Cabrillo. The name Anacapa is a corruption of Vancouver's spelling of the Indian name of the island.

Professor George Davidson, late of the United States Coast and Geodetic Survey, in his valuable Appendix to the "Report of the Survey for 1886," says that, "Vancouver in his text names it Enneeapah, but the engraver has spelled it Enecapah on the chart, and subsequent compilers have endeavored to give it a Spanish form. The Indian deep guttural pronunciation is En-ni-ah-pagh."

When Cabrillo cruised along the coast

of what is now called Southern California, he found the mainland between Point Concepcion and San Buenaventura dotted by villages inhabited by aborigines who were at that time peaceably inclined toward their strange visitors. The old navigators inform us that they found "seventeen populous villages or towns within a distance of eleven miles along the shore of the Santa Barbara Channel." The islands, distant from twenty-five to one hundred miles from the coast, were thickly inhabited by tribes, who, though speaking different languages or dialects, were closely related to those of the mainland, and were branches of the same family or stock.

After Cabrillo's departure there is a wide gap in the history of the region, until some two hundred and twenty-five years later, the revered Father Junipero Serra and his associates established the Franciscan missions at the most densely populated localities. From these central points of ecclesiastical and temporal authority, which soon became like walled cities, with their busy hum of labor, the padres enthusiastically and conscientiously worked to civilize and christianize the untutored natives, and when this could not be accomplished by fair means, their retainers were sent out to capture them and bring them in by force, keeping them close prisoners within the walled surroundings of the missions, until by moral suasion they should become reconciled to the restraint upon their wonted liberty and freedom of action. As these neophytes became tamed and well under the control of the padres, they were sent out to help the Spaniards capture and bring others into the fold.

As time went on the padres extended their dominion until the outlying islands were conquered, and their inhabitants brought to the mainland for more complete subjection to the influence of civil-

ization, until the last remnants of the natives of the islands San Miguel, Santa Rosa, Santa Cruz, the Anacapas, Santa Catalina, San Nicolas, and San Clemente, were removed to the mainland, all except one notable instance which has furnished the subject of many a romantic story, the facts of which will be narrated further on.

Previous to the final removal, however, the Russian fur traders of the North had made inroads upon the natives. At first they were friendly and bartered with the peaceful inhabitants for the skins of sea otter and seals, which at that time abounded on the shores. After they had gained the confidence of the natives, they brought down some of the treacherous Innuits of the North, leaving them upon the islands to trade with the natives to better advantage; the Russians making visits at stated times, to gather up the accumulations of their subordinates, and furnish them supplies for carrying on the barter. From tradition, we learn that these Northern Indians finally massacred large numbers of the unsuspecting natives, carrying away with them everything of value belonging to the inhabitants.

I formed one of a party, which some years ago spent several weeks on one of the Channel Islands collecting ethnological specimens for the Smithsonian Institution. We exhumed a large number of skeletons of the former inhabitants, and at one place found where a large number, probably two or three hundred, had been buried; they had evidently been thrown into heaps without system or ceremony, a majority of the skulls showing evidence of their owners having been killed by the driving of some blunt-pointed instrument through the temporal bone, or into the socket of the eye. There was also an almost entire absence of the usual deposits made with the dead bodies when bur-

ied by their own people, — which would indicate either that they had been thrown into a heap and left unburied and afterwards covered by the drifting sand, or they had been hurriedly and unceremoniously buried by enemies, or by friends who had not time nor opportunity to perform the usual ceremonies, nor to deposit the individual belongings, as was their custom.

It may be doubted whether the original inhabitants of the islands selected the sites for their habitations in consideration of their romantic positions or grand scenic surroundings, but they certainly did occupy some of the most sightly positions to be found in their territory, probably from the combined objects of being near the source of food supply, water, fuel, and positions commanding a view of the surrounding country, to guard against being surprised by an approaching enemy.

During the greater portion of the year no shelter was needed, or at most a brush shelter was sufficient, although the natives built houses of the ribs of stranded whales. These were set up on end in the ground in the form of a circle. The concave curves, being towards the center, brought the upper ends together at the top, and the outside was probably covered by stretching seal skins over the frame, making a substantial wind and water proof building in the form of an old-fashioned bee-hive.

In the exploration before mentioned, I found the remains of buildings of this character in which the portions of the bones imbedded in the soil were preserved *in situ*, the portions above ground having disappeared, indicating that the houses were ancient, the bones of the whale being very durable, as is shown by the large numbers of such bones which were to be found in the neighborhood of the rancherias, or villages, a long



THE REMAINS OF THE LOST PEOPLE, SAN NICOLAS ISLAND.

time subsequent to the disappearance of the Indians from the region. Bones of whales were also used in the burial places to indicate the position of the bodies. Mr. Paul Schumacher during his explorations of the islands and coast in 1875, sometimes mistook the remains of these houses for indications of burial places.

Ferrelo, in writing of *El Pueblo de los Canoas* ("which is called Xucu"), which Professor Davidson locates as the San Buenaventura of today, says, "And they saw on the land a village of Indians near the sea, and the houses large in the manner of those of New Spain" (Mexico).

Natural caves, of which large numbers exist around the shores of the islands, were also used by untold generations of inhabitants. Some of these caves worn in the face of the perpendicular basaltic cliffs, are accessible only from the ocean; others are situated inland. During a recent visit to the islands, our party explored several of these aboriginal strongholds, or cave dwellings, in some of which we found Kitchen-middings, or Kjekken moddings, several feet in depth, among which we found shells, bones of birds, seals, sea-otter, and fish, fragments of rope made of sea grass, and a few fragments of stone implements. Some of the grass ropes were braided in three strands, others twisted like ordinary rope used at the present day. The largest cave on the Anacapas, into which we rowed our boat, consists of a chamber of perhaps four hundred feet in width, running back about one hundred and fifty feet from the arched entrance, with a dome-shaped roof perhaps one hundred feet in height, rising from the circumference in a regular curve to the center, the

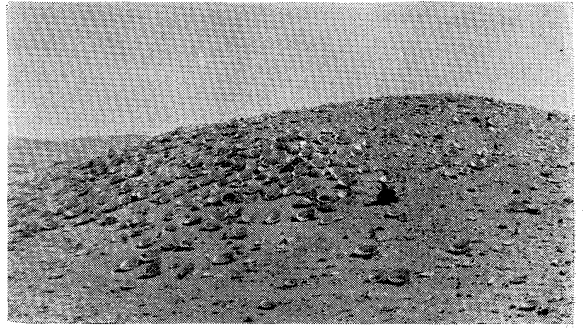


THE COAST CLIFFS, 1000 FEET HIGH.

floor being partly covered by water edged by a pebbly beach, forming a grand hall which would accommodate a large number of people.

In passing along the bluffs in which the caves are situated, they present a panorama of unique and beautiful scenery where the richness of color and peculiarity of outline are unequaled at any other point. The water for a great portion of the distance is perfectly smooth, and so transparent that the flora and fauna of its depths may be as easily studied as upon the surface ; bright orange-colored fishes darting in and out among the dark green seaweeds, the shells, corallines, and other inhabitants of the deep, can there be seen in their native element.

At other points rock-shelters, or shal-



FIELDS OF ABALONE SHELLS.

low caves, had been occupied, some of which are some distance from the sea shore. Near the eastern end of Santa Rosa Island there are quite a number of the rock-shelters which project above the general surface. One isolated rock-shelter in the side of a cañon at some distance from the sea, and at a height of some thirty or forty feet from the bottom of the cañon or ravine, had its floor covered with refuse, and a few human bones were found in the debris, possibly the remains of some of the former inhabitants who had sought shelter from their enemies or been outcasts from their kind, had died, and left their bones unburied.

Human bones are often found buried in the spaces occupied by depressions which mark the sites of these ancient dwellings, especially in instances where the rancherias or former dwelling places occupied the only convenient spot in which the soil could be easily excavated.

On the middle Anacapa, a short distance from the only buildings upon the island, we found a rock-shelter or cave facing towards the main land, which would afford shelter from the storms of winter, which generally come from the southeast, south, or southwest. We found an extensive deposit of refuse at this point, and also at other places on this island ; although Mr. Schumacher informs us that he "passed this island from all sides but could not discover any shell deposits."



A BIT OF THE SAN NICOLAS COAST.



THE CAVE DWELLINGS, SAN NICOLAS ISLAND.

The Ancient Mariners, or Navigators, remained on the islands from November 23rd, 1542, until January 19th, 1543, and reported the inhabitants as very poor. "They eat nothing but fish, they sleep on the ground, all their business and employment is to fish; in each house they say there are fifty souls, they live very swinishly, they go naked."

San Nicolas Island is about nine miles in length and four miles in width, and contains about 322 square miles. The water on the island is plentiful, but brackish; it was formerly densely populated, but is now a treeless waste, the result of its having been denuded of its former natural growth of trees and other vegetation by fire, and the pasturage of sheep.

We learn from tradition that the Alaska Indians placed upon this island to trade with the natives, killed off the male inhabitants and took possession. Later, when they left the island, they abandoned the women and children.

In 1835, some years after the Alaskans

had departed, the padres sent a vessel to remove the women and children from the island. This was accomplished with the exception of one woman who jumped into the surf and swam ashore to hunt for her child, which had accidentally been left behind. The next we hear of the lone woman was in 1850, after a lapse of fifteen years, when Captain Nidever of Santa Barbara visited the island, and discovered traces of recent habitation, but it was not until 1853 that the female Robinson Crusoe was found and removed to the main land, where, from the sudden and complete change of manner of living, she soon died. She had outlived her people, and found no one able to converse with her in her almost forgotten language. It is supposed she was the last of her race. Her child, for whom she returned, is said to have been killed by dogs, which were abundant upon the island at the time of its occupation by the Indians. These dogs have since become extinct.

The child's dress, together with other relics found with the woman, including

needles of bone, clothing made of skins, and the like, were deposited in the Vatican at Rome, but the incidents connected with her stay upon, and removal from, the island, will soon be forgotten, although the refuse heaps of the thousands of its former inhabitants will remain for ages as the only evidence of a lost people.

Who can realize the utter and wretched loneliness of the poor creature who spent eighteen years among the deserted homes and hearths of generations of her ancestors, whose bleaching bones were exposed by the action of the prevailing winds, until the surface of the ground was whitened by their numbers?

Some of the islands nearest to the mainland are occupied by the white race, who have taken away or destroyed nearly all the destructible evidences of its former occupation. The majority of the smaller islands have been used as pasture, and the only human occupants are the nomadic sheep shearers, who remain only during the shearing seasons; an occa-

sional visit from a sealing party, or fishermen, and of late years by parties of Chinamen, who have collected immense quantities of abalones (*Haliotis*), the soft parts of which are dried and shipped to China, and the shells sold by the ton for the manufacture of buttons and jewelry.

The whalers and seal hunters have plied their vocations so persistently that the large marine animals which supplied an important part of the wants of the aborigines, have been almost exterminated, and the abalones, which furnished the natives with a permanent food supply, have been shipped to far off Asia to serve as food for the over-populated dominions of the Oriental Empire.

The deserted homes of the lost people remain in almost unbroken solitude, the silence broken only by the moaning of the winds, the muffled rolling of the ever moving surf, the harsh discordant screaming of the sea birds, and the sonorous deep-toned barking of seals and sea lions.

Lorenzo Gordin Yates, F. L. S.

Corresponding Member Anthropological Society.

BIRTH.

GOD smiled upon the earth,—and so
 Spring came; the blooms began to blow
 Upon the almond tree;
 The birds dropped down from heaven's blue
 And caroled all the morning through
 In sweetest melody.

God smiled upon the heart,—and so
 Love came; the soul began to glow
 With its divinity;
 The mighty chain of nations came
 And from the forge of tender flame
 Linked God, and man, and majesty.

Elwyn Irving Hoffman.